Social media supplement

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Introduction

The main part of this book focuses on writing emails, but today people spend a lot of time writing on social media platforms as well. This short supplement introduces these platforms.

Text messages (SMS) and instant messaging (online chat)

You send text messages on a mobile phone (cellphone). A text message can be called simply a 'text'. Instant messaging (IM) is similar, but is online and often people reply immediately. SMS and IM both use a similar language – very informal, short forms, missing words etc.

IM started as a chat medium for friends sitting at their computers in the evening. Yahoo Messenger and Microsoft Messenger were the dominant platforms. Skype added the option of voice (like a telephone call) and live video. With the arrival of social media and smartphones, IM is developing into anytime, anywhere group chat.

Facebook

In the early days Facebook (FB) was used for posting text and photographs, for commenting on other people's posts, and for text-based chat. Now FB integrates the latest media-rich services alongside text and images.

It also tries constantly to enter the territory of the other platforms. For example it has professional groups to compete with LinkedIn, and photo-sharing tools to compete with Flickr and Picasa.

Google+

You can have multiple 'circles' of contacts within Google+ (G+). For example, you can keep your communications with personal friends and professional contacts separate.

It allows you to post photos and brief updates that are visible to anyone in the world, just to members of a particular circle, or to individuals. The integrated Google Hangouts allow you to have spontaneous multi-person video chats with members of a particular circle who happen to be online when you are.

LinkedIn

LinkedIn (LI) is a social networking site for professionals. You start by posting your CV/resume, then you build up a network of connections. You can let people know what you are doing and join professional groups. You can also look for jobs.

With LI you send messages to your connections just like email. There are also many discussions in the various professional groups, and here the writing style is more careful and structured than on other social media platforms.

A LinkedIn 'connection' is similar to a Facebook 'friend' or a Twitter 'follower'.

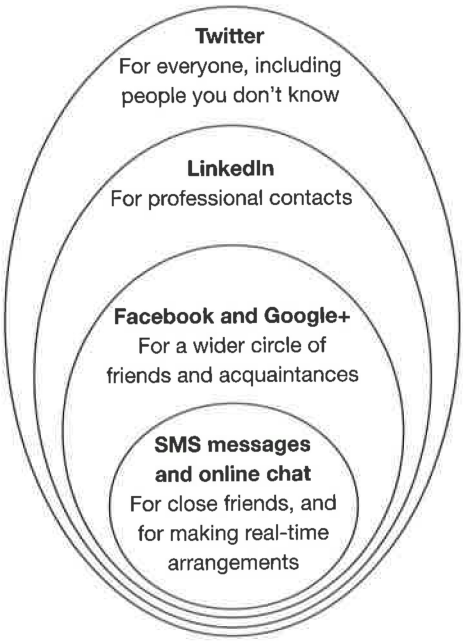
Twitter

Using Twitter you send very short messages known as 'tweets'. If you read an interesting tweet, you can retweet it to your followers. Conversations develop, and you can read these or join in at any time. Depending on who you follow, you can read tweets on almost any topic, from IM-style chat between friends, to comments on news events, to recommendations for interesting websites, to train companies updating passengers on delays.

You can search for a particular topic using a hashtag (#). This symbol is used to show key words in a tweet. There are also live hashtag chat sessions where all the tweets are on a particular topic, all including # and the topic name.

Looking at the different platforms

Any description of social media runs the risk of going out of date. But at the time of writing, the following was largely true:



Facebook ✓ Best for interacting at a more personal level. ✗ Having too many friends dilutes the genuine connections; can take over your life.

Google+ ✓ Best for having conversations with specific circles rather than everyone; good video conferencing tools. ✗ Fewer users due to late arrival on scene; unclear whether it's for friends (like FB) or professionals (like LI).

LinkedIn ✓ Best for showing others what you have done professionally, and for reading discussions on issues in your field. ✗ Misuse of discussion groups for promoting new products.

Twitter ✓ Best for short, focused updates to a wide audience, and for following hashtags on topical issues. ✗ Most tweets are read by very few people; some people who follow you just want to get noticed so that you follow them back.

Most platforms would like to get the market of the others. So FB would like to compete with LI for use by professionals. Similarly, G+ wants to compete with both LI and FB. There is also a strong tendency for the various platforms to converge – so if one introduces a new service then the others soon follow.

In any case, it is likely that much will have changed by the time you read this. In the social media world strategies and services develop all the time.

This supplement to *email English*

Writing on a social media platform is a little different to writing an email. This supplement first explores Facebook, Google+, LinkedIn and Twitter in more detail. Then it shows you over several pages how to write in a friendly, informal style that is appropriate for the online world.

You will find much in this supplement that is also relevant to emails, particularly informal non-business emails. And likewise, many units in the main part of the book are also relevant to social media.

Enjoy your writing! Have fun with social media!

Paul Emmerson, Worthing, UK, June 2012
www.macmillanenglish.com/authors

Platforms

Facebook

On Facebook (FB) you create a profile (timeline). This is like a webpage where you include your name, photo and information about yourself. To connect with other people on Facebook you first have to become 'friends' with each other.

Facebook is continually reinventing itself and adding features. The key feature however is the status update where you type a message and share it with your friends. This message can be a personal message (about what you are doing), a question, or a link to another website. All your friends see your status updates, and you can see theirs.

Other features of FB include the ability to create groups. These can be groups of friends, professional groups, groups of people with a common interest, etc. On FB you can also play online games with and against other people.

Facebook has various levels of privacy. Some of your information (name, profile photo) is visible to anyone searching FB, while other information is only visible to your friends.

Facebook also allows businesses and professionals to create FB pages. The difference between a Facebook page and a Facebook profile is that a page does not have friends – instead it has 'likes'. If you find a Facebook page of a brand, company or celebrity that you like, you can click on the 'like' button. You will then see their status updates on your profile page in your news feed.

Why use Facebook?

Because so many people have profiles on Facebook, it is sometimes the easiest way to find and contact a friend.

Having a profile on FB means:

- You can keep in touch with friends and family easily, as well as ask for advice or help from all your friends at once.
- You can share photos and news about your life without the need to send everyone an email.
- You can join groups of people with similar interests, or create a group about something you are interested in yourself. You make new friends that way.
- You can promote your business by setting up a Facebook page and giving special offers or information to those who 'like' you.
- You can publicize an event on Facebook (a party, or product launch, or conference) and invite people. It's an easy way for people to see things that are going on.

Tips on using Facebook

1. Complete your profile with the information you feel comfortable sharing with friends. Facebook offers you the possibility of sharing lots of information, but you don't have to let everybody know everything about you.
2. Update your status regularly. It will make your profile more interesting.
3. Add photos and videos to bring your profile to life.
4. Look around for Facebook groups.
5. If you have a business, think about setting up a Facebook Page and put aside time to regularly update it with news.
6. Think before you post, and make sure you check your account's privacy settings to control who sees what. Facebook keeps everything, and there are many stories of people posting photos or status updates that they later regretted!

Google+

On Google+ (G+), you create a profile with your name, photo and basic information such as where you live, where you went to school/university, and where you work. To connect with people, you add them to one of your 'circles'. If they belong to G+, they don't have to consent to be added to one of your circles, but they may receive a notification about it. You can have as many different circles as you want, so it might be a good idea to keep personal friends separate from work colleagues or people you know through a hobby or club. Circles are what differentiates G+ from other social media tools. Posting updates and photos is done in a way that is similar to Facebook, but in G+ you can choose who is able to see each item you post. You can make a post visible to the whole world, but it's probably better just to let people in one particular circle see it. If you have something more personal to post, you can even share it with just one person from a circle, so no one else will see it.

In addition to people who agree to be in one of your circles, you are also encouraged to 'follow' public figures and organizations. This just means that you add them to a circle called 'Following', so you will see updates that they post. This is like Twitter, but with people you follow being in a separate circle.

Another popular feature of G+ is the 'Hangouts', where you can easily start a video conference with people in your circles who have indicated that they are online and available for a Hangout. Currently, a Hangout can include up to nine people at a time and, in addition to video chatting, participants can watch YouTube videos simultaneously or sketch on a whiteboard.

Why use Google+?

As G+ becomes more widely known, more and more people will join and it will be easier to find friends there. There is also a tool you can use to invite your friends to join G+.

By adding G+ to your Google.com account, you can:

- Keep in touch with friends and classmates.
- Connect with colleagues while keeping them separate from personal friends, so maintaining a professional image.
- Use the Hangouts with friends for quick and easy video chats.
- Use the Hangouts with colleagues or clients for screen-sharing, collaborative editing (Google Docs), discussions and work sessions.
- Contact professionals from around the world who you may not be able to meet in person.
- Follow the activities of public figures and organizations that are important to you.

Tips on using Google+

1 Complete your profile with information that you feel comfortable sharing with the world, because it will be visible to everyone, and will be how people find you to connect with you.

2 Although you can move people in and out of circles easily, as soon as you add someone to a particular circle, they can see everything you've ever written and every photo you've ever posted to that circle. Be careful who you put in what circle.

3 Add posts regularly to keep it interesting, but only share them with the appropriate circles. Your boss may not be keen on finding out that you took a long lunch with friends, and your personal friends may not be interested in your congratulations to a colleague on a promotion.

4 Take advantage of the close integration of Google Docs with Hangouts. The existence of an office utilities suite in G+ is one thing that really separates it from the other platforms.

LinkedIn

LinkedIn (LI) is a social networking site for professional people. You first build an online CV/resume using the given LI format, and then build your network ('connections') starting with people you already know. You can invite other new people to join, and once someone has agreed to be part of your network, you can contact them directly. LI also suggests people you might like to connect with.

A key feature of LI is the different professional 'groups'. These can be very general (eg for all lawyers), or very specific (eg for lawyers in a specific town working in a specific area of law). You can join any group you want to, and read and contribute to the discussions there.

Another feature of LI is its Jobs section, and here you can apply for jobs that companies have advertised. An employer might also read your profile and contact you directly. You can also approach other individuals yourself to offer them work (very useful for freelancers).

There are also showcase pages for companies (like with Facebook) and you can follow individuals or companies (like with Twitter).

Finally, your LinkedIn and Twitter activity can be integrated, if you choose. Tweets can appear in your LI profile, and LI updates and posts can be tweeted.

Why use LinkedIn?

By having a profile on LinkedIn you:

- Increase your visibility and personal branding.
- Build trust. Through your connections, you show who you know. You can also ask for 'recommendations' where people will give personal testimonials about working with you.
- Direct traffic to your blog or website.

And as an active user of LinkedIn you can:

- Get in contact with professionals from around the world who you would normally never meet.
- Follow the discussions in the groups you have joined, and read expert opinion and debate there. You can also contribute yourself.
- Look for work, or show that you are available for different kinds of work.
- Research companies and individuals before you contact them, and after they contact you.
- Ask for advice, and get responses from people in your network.
- Contact people whose email address you don't know, or who have changed jobs.

Tips on using LinkedIn

1. In your profile, give attention to the summary and the photograph.
2. Ask for recommendations from your managers and colleagues.
3. In groups, join the conversation and don't be shy. Give ideas, opinions and information in a friendly, fun yet focussed way. Be responsive and interactive.
4. Join groups where your colleagues are, and also where your customers are.
5. Send occasional messages to your connections about things of benefit to them, such as news of professional events. In return you earn the 'right' to occasionally self-promote.
6. If you see a job you want to apply for, you can search for other people already in that company, then research their backgrounds and their posts to group discussions.
7. Continue to build and nurture your network even if your career is going well. You never know when or how you will need support in the future.

Twitter

Twitter is a website where you can post messages (called 'tweets') of up to 140 characters long. If people like your tweets, they can 'follow' you, and in this case all your tweets will appear in their timeline. In the same way, you get tweets from all the people you follow.

Once you have sent a tweet, there are several possible responses from other Twitter users. They might:

- Do nothing, because they never read your tweet in the first place. This is by far the most common situation because of the information overload on Twitter.
- Send you a message in response. This may be a tweet directed just at you, or may be a more general tweet that continues the conversation and is for everyone to read and respond to.
- Send you a (private) direct message. This will arrive by email as well as Twitter.
- Retweet your message. This means sending the tweet to their own followers.
- Follow you (if they are not already doing so).
- A combination of the above.

Why use Twitter?

With Twitter you can:

- Follow people you are interested in. At a personal level this may be a friend or a celebrity, or at a professional level it may be a thought leader or key player in your industry.
- Find information about a topic using the hashtag sign (#). For example, if you type '#esl' into the Search box you will see all (and only) tweets relating to English as a second language. But this example shows how the # must be used carefully, as '#esl' includes tweets aimed at both teachers and learners. You will soon find out the hashtags that are most relevant to you.
- Follow an event live, as it happens. So if you type '#election' you will see tweets relating to this topic. But again, this hashtag may not be the best: for example it may be too general (which election?). Of course you can also make a comment on the event yourself by using the relevant hashtag.
- Promote yourself or your company. For example if you update your personal blog, or your company is organizing an event, then you tweet it. You hope that these tweets will get retweeted and read by others.
- Find information by tweeting a question: someone may know the answer.
- Tweet to give personal news, just like other platforms. Or tweet that you are going to be somewhere at a particular time and ask who else will be there.

Tips on using Twitter

1 Spend time creating a good profile page. You don't know who will read this – it could be a potential employer.

2 Make your tweets interesting, focussed and relevant. And, surprisingly, the vast majority of tweets use full words – they are much easier to read.

3 Look for relevant hashtags. As a starter, try the one for your town.

4 If you want to build up followers, tweet often: several times a day. Remember that most tweets are only read by a few people.

5 Ask active Twitter users about which tools they use. There are many tools to separate the useful tweets from the 'noise'.

Writing for social media

Formality, tone and politeness

Look at these examples from emails:

1 Can you pick me up from the airport? My stuff weighs a ton. But if you're busy, don't worry – I'll take a taxi. See you Tuesday. Should be fun!

(informal, friendly)

2 Pick me up from the airport please. I have two heavy bags. We will meet on Tuesday as planned. I look forward to it.

(informal, but a little unfriendly)

3 Would it be possible for you to pick me up from the airport? I would really appreciate it. If it's not convenient, don't worry because I can easily take a taxi. I look forward to seeing you on Tuesday.

(formal, friendly, polite)

There are three issues here. One is formality (informal vs formal), another is tone (friendly vs unfriendly) and another is politeness (polite vs rude). These issues are closely connected but not the same. And there are strong cultural factors at play: example 3 above is friendly and polite in some cultures, but too indirect and insincere in others.

How do I write in an appropriate style?

There is no magic answer because it all depends on the speakers and the situation. However we can make some general comments:

Informal, friendly language. This style appears in social media and in emails between friends. It has informal words like *stuff*. It has lots of little words like *actually*, *anyway*, *just* and *really*. It has vague language such as *things like that* or *a couple of* (notice how the precise '*two bags*' in #2 above seems unfriendly). It uses exaggeration: things are *amazing* rather than *good*. It often misses out small words (see page 80). And it typically uses more words than necessary in order to express feelings and build the relationship.

Informal, unfriendly language. This style appears when the writer tries to be simple and direct, but in doing so is emotionally cold. It has commands rather than requests. It is too factual and precise. It lacks extra words that show feelings and enthusiasm. It fails to give choices.

Polite language. Look at example #3 above: *Would it be possible for you to pick me up …?* instead of *Can you pick me up …?* The formula at work is:

indirect language + more words = polite

Some people believe that this formula allows you to show respect, for example it allows the reader to save face (it is easier to say 'no'). But politeness is cultural, and other people find that indirect language is confusing and insincere – they think it is better to be simple, clear and direct. It is often said that indirect language is associated with the UK, Southern Europe and Asia, while direct language is associated with the USA and Northern Europe.

Another way to think of polite language is that it is like a letter rather than an email. In other words, it is a little more formal, has more fixed expressions, and shows a generally more careful use of language.

Business emails: situation and content

Many business emails are simple and direct. But the style may change because of the situation. Consider three emails describing a new product: one to your boss, one to a colleague, and one to a client. The relationships are different and so the emails will be

different. Style also depends on the content: an email on a serious matter is likely to be more formal, no matter who the reader is.

Short forms (text message language)

A text message can also be called a 'text' or an SMS. Text message language uses short forms mixed with slang. It is also found in online chat and on some social media platforms. It developed because of the difficulty of typing full words on small mobile phone keyboards.

SMS language can be broken down into these areas:

Words or sounds → letters or numbers

are → r	see you → cu
before → b4	thanks → thx
for → 4	tomorrow → 2moro
great → gr8	you → u
later → l8r	your/you're → ur

Common words → shortened

message → msg	very → v
please → pls	would → wd
regarding → re	your → yr

Expressions → first letters of words

ASAP → as soon as possible
BTW → by the way
FYI → for your information
OTOH → on the other hand
TIA → thanks in advance
BW → best wishes

Other ways to shorten words

There are other ways to shorten words:

- A slash (/) can replace missing letters, so *w/* means *with* and *w/e* means *weekend*
- & means *and*; @ means *at*

In fact, more or less any word or phrase can be shortened in social media writing if the context makes it clear:

No problem, I'll see you in 30 minutes.
→ No probs, c u 30 mins.

I'll meet Dan at the station on Wednesday.
→ I'll meet D at stn Weds.

I'm going to go back home now – I've got all the information I need.
→ Gonna go bk home. Got all info.

Short forms in context

Short forms like those above are found in text messages, online chat and social media. However they are not very common in emails.

Factors that affect the use of short forms include:

Age. The use of text message language is strongly age-related, with people born after about 1980 using it freely.

Situation. In a business context, use text message language with care. For example, BTW or BW are fine, but LOL ('laughing out loud') would never be used in a business context, despite being very common in social media.

Platform. On Facebook short forms are quite common as the medium is very informal. On LinkedIn very few short forms are found (professional people have to present an 'educated' image to the outside world). On Twitter the messages have a limit of 140 characters, and so you would expect to find many short forms here. However, the great majority of words in Twitter are written in full, and sentences are generally well-formed. It seems that Twitter users prefer the ease of reading a 'proper' full sentence.

Access to a full-sized keyboard. Given a full-sized keyboard, most people reduce their use of short forms. And even in text messages, short forms are becoming rarer due to new text input methods.

Missing out words

With text messages, online chat, social media and informal emails you can miss out some small words completely. In grammar this is called ellipsis.

But in business English it is usually not a good idea to miss out words (unless you are writing to a colleague you know well). You do not want any chance of misunderstanding. You want your message to be clear, unambiguous and easy to read.

Miss out *I*

The subject *I* can be missed out, especially with verbs like *hope*, *think* etc.

I hope you're well.
→ Hope you're well.

Miss out *I am / I have / I will*

The two-word phrases *I am*, *I have* and *I will* can be missed out when they are followed by a main verb.

I'm really enjoying the holiday.
→ Really enjoying the holiday.

I've bought the tickets.
→ Bought the tickets.

I'll see you later.
→ See you later.

Miss out *Do you / Did you / Have you*

In a question, the auxiliary verb and the subject *you* can be missed out.

Do you see what I mean?
→ See what I mean?

Did you enjoy the movie?
→ Enjoy the movie?

Have you had a chance to read it yet?
→ Had a chance to read it yet?

Miss out a form of *be*

Sometimes a form of *be* (*is/was/would be*) can be missed out if it is followed by an adjective.

I think next week would be better.
→ I think next week better.

This is particularly common in lists of short points, for example:

Supplier #2: cost high, quality good, delivery time acceptable.

Miss out *It/That/It's a/That's a*

The subjects *It* or *That* can be missed out, often with a form of *be* as well.

It could take longer than you think.
→ Could take longer than you think.

That sounds like fun.
→ Sounds like fun.

It's a great idea.
→ Great idea.

That's a pity – I was looking forward to it.
→ Pity – I was looking forward to it.

Miss out *the*

Sometimes the word *the* can be missed out.

What time is the meeting?
→ What time is meeting?

I just read the email about the contract.
→ Just read email about contract.

Missing out words in speech

Many examples on this page are also found in informal speech. But not all the examples on this page work well in speech. For example, the following would sound like beginner-level English, if spoken:

I think next week better.
Just read email about contract.

Bringing a sentence to life

In informal writing we use little words like *actually*, *really*, *just*, *well* and *anyway*. They show feelings, introduce your next point, or make a meaning stronger or softer. Look at how they bring a sentence to life:

1 a) *We had a great time.* (dead sentence)
   b) ***Actually**, we had a **really** great time.*

2 a) *It's a small problem.* (dead sentence)
   b) ***Anyway**, it's **just** a small problem.*

In all the examples on this page these little words could be missed out. But putting them in makes the writing friendlier.

actually

The word *actually* is used in several ways.

surprising but true (like *in fact* or *really*)

***Actually**, it's not very far. We could even walk.*
***Actually**, it's not that expensive.*

introducing something important

***Actually**, there's a problem with the contract.*
***Actually**, I need to speak to you about it.*

correcting the other person

***Actually**, it was Daniel not Leon who told me.*
***Actually**, she's Scottish not English. Be careful!*

And note that *actually* is a false friend in many languages. In English it does NOT have a time reference to now.

really

The words *really* and *not really* can be used to make an idea stronger or softer.

*It was **really** amazing.*
*Great! Let's do that. I **really** love Chinese food.*
*I **really don't** think that's a good idea.*
*I **don't really** like Bar Zero. What about …?*
*Either one is good. I **don't really** mind.*

just

The word *just* is used in many ways. You might know the first three, but look at the other two uses.

*I've **just** finished.* (*just* = a short time ago)
*It isn't **just** me.* (*just* = *only*)
***Just** as I expected!* (*just* = *exactly*)

just to make an idea softer

*I have to go to hospital – **just** a few days.*
*Don't worry, it's **just** a small thing.*

just to politely ask or tell something

*Can I **just** ask you something?*
*Sorry about last night. Can I **just** explain?*
*I **just** wanted to let you know that …*

well and *anyway*

The words *anyway* and *well* can be used in similar ways. They show a change in direction in your writing. In the examples below either word can be used.

responding with a statement

***Well**, I agree with you about the movie.*

asking a question

***Well**, what are we going to do now?*

continuing after a digression

***Well**, as I was saying, …*

concluding or summarizing

***Anyway**, it was great fun. After that we …*
***Anyway**, it was worth it. Next time I think I'll …*
***Anyway**, we need to talk more about it.*
***Anyway**, we can't do anything until we hear from them.*

preparing to close

***Anyway**, that's all for now. Speak soon.*
***Anyway**, I'll tell you more on Saturday.*

Being friendly

Friendliness is at the heart of social media, and in social media, friendly language is used with people you have never met. All the techniques on pages 79–85 help you to sound friendly when you write. Here are a few other ideas.

Questions

Before starting the main topic, ask questions in the first few lines you write. This shows interest in the other person.

Hi. How r u?
Stefan here. How's it going?
Hey Paula. What did u do at the w/e?
Wow! 3-1 to us. Did you see the match?

These are not real questions, and the other person can choose not to reply, or just to reply very generally.

Alternatively, you can start by giving your own news first and then ask a question.

I just got back from vacation. What about you? Did you go to Greece with Angela?

Sorry it's taken so long. Moved to another flat and been sorting things out. Any news? How about meeting up for a coffee?

Short, personal responses

We can respond to someone with a short, personal comment. After that we can add a follow-up comment or question. See the examples below.

pleasure

We can hv meal 2nite after movie.
→ ***Great.*** / ***Great idea.*** / ***Perfect.*** *Thx for org everything. Look fwd to it.*

Stronger expressions of pleasure are: ***Excellent!*** / ***Fantastic!*** / ***Wonderful!***

surprise

You'll never guess who I saw yesterday… Irina!
→ ***Really?*** / ***Wow!*** / ***Amazing!*** / ***You're kidding, right?*** ***What a surprise!*** *What happened?*

confirmation

Trying to find yr house. Am at big s/market on corner.
→ ***Good.*** / ***That's right.*** / ***Exactly.*** / ***Perfect.*** *Now left down Church St. I'm on right after 200m.*

Other standard responses include:

Congratulations! / *Great news!*
Really? / *That's interesting.*
Definitely. / *Absolutely.* / *Absolutely right.*
Definitely not. / *Absolutely not.*
Good luck! / *I'm sure you'll do really well.*
That's a pity. / *That's bad news.*

Short, funny, chatty comments

In the informal context of online chat, people often make short, funny, personal comments. They have little meaning but help to build the relationship. Below are some random examples. They could be used alone, or as the first part of a longer comment with more content.

Haha. Just read yr latest post. Great stuff!
Oh, c'mon. Surely u don't believe that?
Just uploaded the rest of my Vienna pics. Enjoy.
Great read, Phil! Keep up the good work.
Loved your post about online gaming. LOL.
Congrats Vicky. You deserve it!
Thanks! Skype this week? Time?
Great to see u yesterday. Btw, loved your shoes!

Being polite

The most common way to be polite in writing is to use indirect language. This language is diplomatic: it avoids strong opinions, it gives choices, and it allows the other person to save face.

could, would

We use *could* and *would* to soften a request or suggestion. The words *perhaps*, *possibly* and *just* can also be added.

Compare:

Please speak to Nicola about this.
→ **Could** *you* **possibly/just** *have a word with Nicola about this?*

Can u get here b4 six?
→ **Wd** *it b poss 4 u to get here b4 six?*

When we try to persuade people, the negative form *couldn't* is more indirect than *can* or *could*.

Couldn't *you do it tomorrow instead?*
Couldn't *we go somewhere else?*

mind

To make a request, use *Would you mind* + *-ing*.

Would you mind *giving me a hand on Thursday? I'd really appreciate it.*

To ask for permission for yourself, use *Would you mind if I* + past tense.

Would you mind if I *arrived late? I have another appointment that I can't cancel. Sorry about that.*

If you think you might inconvenience someone, you can use *If you don't mind*.

***If you don't mind**, I won't come with you tonight. I'm a little tired.*

think, hope, wonder

We often use these verbs for polite requests (*Can you…?*) and permission (*Can I…?*). Compare:

Can you find out what time it starts?
→ **Do you think you could** *find out …?*

Can I bring a few friends with me?
→ **I hope you don't mind if I** *bring …*
→ **I wonder if I could** *bring …*

We can use all three verbs in the past continuous tense to be very polite.

Can I leave the meeting early?
→ **I was thinking of** *leaving the meeting early, if that's okay with you.*

Can we have a chat at some point?
→ **I was hoping we could** *have a quick chat at some point.*

Can we rearrange the meeting?
→ **I was wondering if** *we might rearrange the meeting.*

I don't think …

We often use *I don't think …* to be diplomatic.

Compare:

You sounded really tired on the phone. **We shouldn't** *go out tonight.*
→ *You sounded really tired on the phone.* **I don't think we should** *go out tonight.*

Mike's been offered a job but **he doesn't want** *it.*
→ *Mike's been offered a job but* **I don't think he wants** *it.*

I'm sorry but … / I'm afraid

The phrase *I'm sorry but* to soften bad news is well-known. In British English the phrase *I'm afraid* is also common. Don't forget to give a reason.

***I'm sorry but** it's not going to be possible. The reason is …*
***I'm afraid** it's not possible. It's because …*

Being vague

The word 'vague' means 'not precise' or 'not exact'. Vague language is more friendly and relaxed; precise language is more cold and inflexible.

I think, I guess, I reckon

A simple way to be vague is to use *I think*.

Are u going 2nite? ***I think*** *it starts 7:30.*
I'm tired. ***I think*** *I might stay in tonight.*

In the above two examples the writer is sure, but using *I think* ... sounds more friendly. We can also use *I guess* and *I reckon* when we are nearly sure, but not 100%.

I reckon *it wd b better to wait till nxt wk.*
Madelina didn't reply to my text. ***I guess*** *she's not interested.*

thing, things, stuff

The word *thing* is a very common vague word.

There's ***a thing*** *at work I have to sort out.*
Let's wait and see how ***things*** *develop.*
Hi! How are ***things*** *over in Poland?*

The word *stuff* is a common alternative to *things*, and very informal.

By the time I got there, all the good ***stuff*** *had gone.*
Yeah, whatever, I know all that ***stuff****.*

sort of, kind of

The words *sort of* and *kind of* can mean 'type of':

What ***sort of*** *conversation did you have?*
What ***kind of*** *car does he drive?*

But they are also used in vague language:

Things are ***sort of*** *difficult between us.*
Sorry I left early – I was feeling ***kind of*** *ill.*

a little, a bit

If we say *very* + adjective it can sound too strong. So we often say *a little* or *a bit* instead. The meaning here is close to 'very', and is not literally 'a little'.

It's ***a little*** *expensive.*
I thought he was ***a bit*** *rude.*
It's ***a little*** *late to call him – I'll do it tomorrow.*

Alternatives to *will*

The word *will* used alone sounds very fixed and certain. It helps if you use a contraction (*'ll*), and there are many vague phrases to refer to the future:

I will be there at 7.
→ ***I'll probably*** *be there* ***around*** *7.*
→ ***Hopefully*** *I'll be there at 7.*
→ *I* ***should be able to*** *get there by 7.*

Time, prices, quantities

With informal writing we often use vague language for time, prices, etc. It would sound strange to use an exact number.

Let's meet after work, ***about/around*** *six.*
It'll only take ***a couple of*** *minutes.*

It costs ***about/around/roughly*** *€200.*
It costs ***just over/just under*** *€200.*

Can you call me tomorrow? There are a ***couple of/one or two*** *things to discuss.*
Next week is going to be difficult – I've got ***loads of*** *work to do.*

We exaggerate time and numbers in a vague way to make our writing more interesting.

I was waiting ***for ages****.*
It took me ***all day*** *to do that spreadsheet.*

There were ***hundreds of/thousands of/millions of*** *people waiting there.*

Making longer posts and comments

On sites such as LinkedIn you can comment on group discussions. Here you should write more carefully as your words might be read by anyone in your professional field.

Start with the conclusion

The standard way to build an argument is to have your conclusion (your own point of view) at the end. The problem with this is that people read very quickly online and may not have the patience to get to the conclusion. So consider putting your conclusion first (after some thanks and points of agreement) and then give the reasons afterwards. Here is an example:

Thanks for posting this, Sandra. It's a great piece and you raise some very important issues. I like your points about … and … . However, I have a different opinion about … I think that … Here are my reasons. First, … And second, … But these are only small points; in general I agree with you and I really enjoyed reading your post.

If you disagree more strongly, think twice before writing. Any strong opinion of yours will be met by an equally strong reaction from others. So you risk becoming unpopular. On the other hand, if you believe something passionately, then go ahead and post. You may become an opinion former yourself! The internet is an open medium where people can argue freely, and it is fun to read a variety of points of view. Just make sure that your post is well-argued (with a logical structure and concrete examples) and not personal. Under no circumstances write in anger.

Build your argument

You can be a little more formal when writing a longer comment for a professional audience.

For example:

and → *In addition/Moreover*
but → *However/On the other hand*
so → *Therefore/As a result*
because → *The reason for this is*

Other linking words and phrases that you will find useful are:

I think / I believe / I am convinced that
First(ly) / Second(ly) / And finally
Clearly / Of course
In general / On the whole
In fact / Actually
For example / eg / such as
In particular
Alternatively
So basically / So what I'm trying to say is
In relation to / With regard to

Remember to use a comma after linking words that begin a sentence:

In general, I agree that … However, I think that …
In particular, I have noticed that … In addition, it is clear to me that … Therefore, I believe that …

Finally, note these two tips:

1 **Write short sentences.** In your language, sentences are probably more complicated than in English. So simplify. Break a long sentence into two short sentences. It will make your writing easier to understand even if the grammar is not perfect. And consider numbering points or using bullets.

2 **Use a 'topic sentence' at the start of each paragraph.** In good writing the first sentence of a paragraph is often a 'topic sentence'. This introduces the ideas in the rest of the paragraph, and makes the argument easier to follow. You will find examples in any magazine-style text or any report.